



THE BLUE DOTS APPROACH: A DISTRICT LIVELIHOODS PLAYBOOK

*A Playbook to unlock hidden jobs and talent in
a district, and strengthen local livelihoods*



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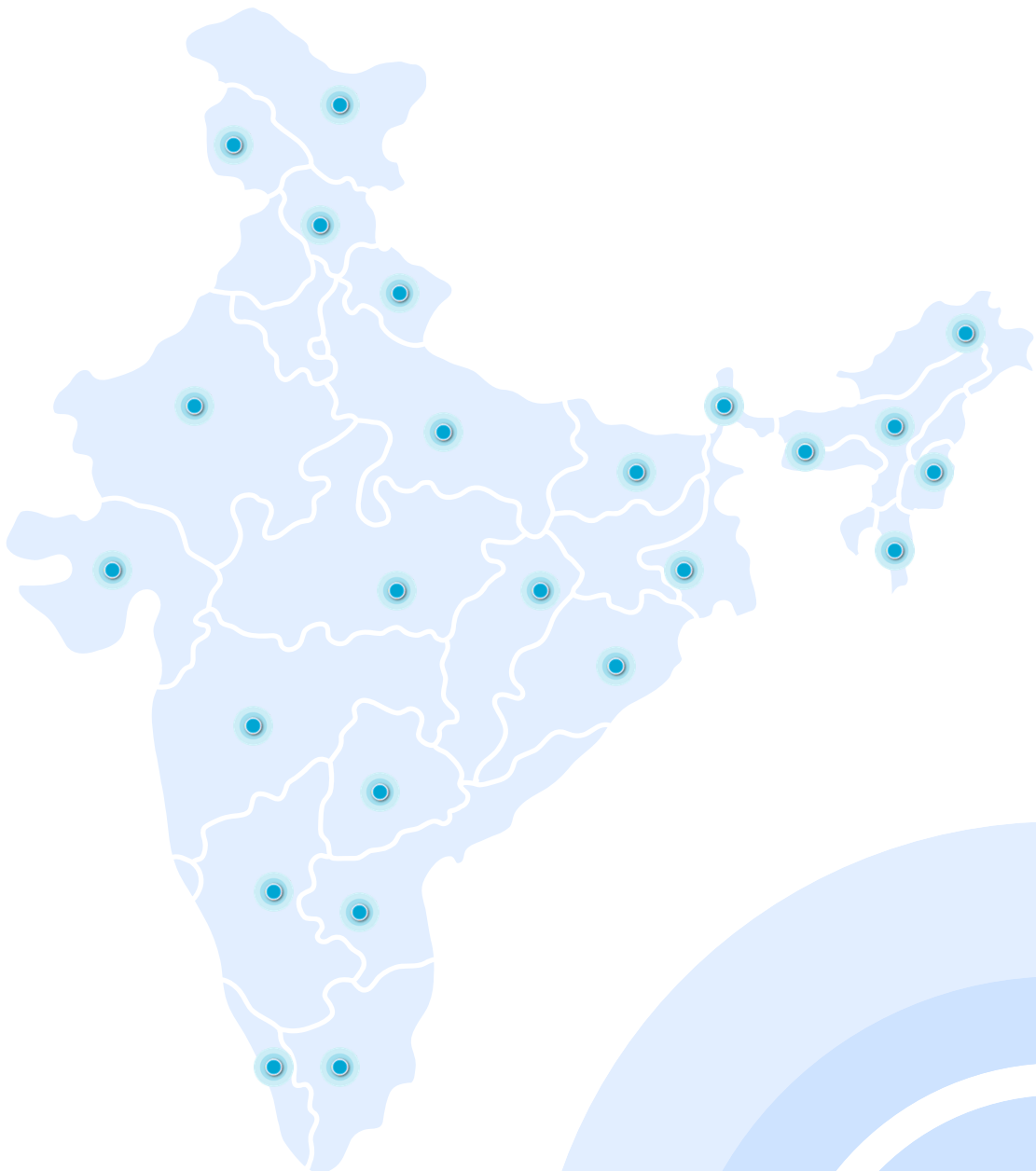
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1. Context

Across India, employment discovery is digitally dark especially for the masses. People and employers are nearby but invisible to each other. Lists sit in registers and spreadsheets, jobs are shared through word of mouth, and trust breaks down when information cannot be verified.

The Blue Dot approach tackles this by enabling timely, credible discovery. It helps districts make local youth, women, any other segment and local jobs visible on a digital map, so they can find and trust each other continuously, not accidentally or with great cost, time and effort.



2. Proof from Ghaziabad & Dharwad

Dharwad and Ghaziabad showed how fixing timely, credible discovery can turn a static local labour market into a living, functioning digital employment ecosystem. When local youth and employers were placed as blue dots on a digital map, proximity surfaced as something very meaningful since both employers and talent are keen on vicinity. Youth & women could see jobs nearby, and employers discovered talent close by that they did not know existed. Hiring became faster, cheaper, and more predictable.

Before	After (with Blue Dot Approach)
Hiring relied on word of mouth and walk-ins	Hiring visible through a live digital map
Employers spent ₹1,000 per hire	Hiring costs dropped by ~10x
Weeks to fill vacancies	Roles filled within days/hours
Unverified candidates caused confusion	Credible profiles
One-off job fairs	Continuous daily shortlists and interviews

What started in Ghaziabad and Dharwad as a small experiment became proof that timely, credible discovery is the foundation of local employment.

3. How to Get Going

Core Idea:



The Blue Dot approach tackles the lack of local discovery and coordination by enabling timely, credible discovery. Every district has enough youth, women, enough employers, and enough intent—but not enough ways to see and connect with each other. The goal is to turn the district into a living digital employment exchange, where:

- Youth & women are discoverable on a map as Blue Dots
- Employers are visible as Blue Dots with job needs
- Application & Matching happens continuously, not occasionally
- Youth, women and employers have direct agency, while district teams (Jobs Facilitation Centre) propagates & sustains the rhythm with the local ecosystem

The Ghaziabad & Dharwad experience showed that success can be enabled by technology, but thrives on simple routines, and a local district ecosystem organizing itself around the initiative.

To get started immediately, a district can begin in a matter of days by following these steps:

Step 0: Align Outcomes, Context & Ownership

Before initiating any on-ground action, it is essential to align on the outcomes Blue Dotting is expected to drive, the program or scheme context in which it is being applied, and the ownership from the government side.

This includes clarity on whether Blue Dotting is being used to strengthen an existing program or scheme (such as a state employment mission, Yuva Nidhi, ITI or college placements), or to anchor a new district or state-level employment initiative. It also requires agreement on the primary outcomes to be driven—such as faster local hiring, increased participation of women and youth, reduction in hiring time and cost, or moving from episodic job fairs to continuous discovery.

- Decide the Program Context: Layer Blue Dotting onto an existing scheme (Yuva Nidhi, ITI/Polytechnic placements, State Employment Mission) or launch a new district/state employment initiative.
- Align Outcomes to Drive: Faster and more predictable local hiring, Increased participation of women and first-time job seekers, Reduction in hiring time and cost, Continuous discovery and placement, instead of episodic job fairs
- Align Geographic Scope: Identify Pilot districts or blocks. Decide on Urban / rural focus. Decide on full-state rollout intent.
- Identify Government Ownership: Identify a single government champion (DC / Mission Director / Secretary level) who owns outcomes, not just approvals. This champion anchor ensures inter-departmental alignment and sustains momentum.

Step 1: Form District PMU & Align Local Ecosystem

- Align Relevant State Level Authorities: Ensure the right departments are aligned at a State Level - Skilling Related Departments, Labour & Employment Related Departments MSME/Industry Related Departments
- Form a District PMU: Put together a 2-3 member PMU team that plays a key role in putting together a district pilot plan, coordinating with relevant ecosystem partners, facilitating progress and convening periodic check-ins.
- Form a Jobs Facilitation Centre (JFC): JFC is an Institutional Structure that engages the local ecosystem by bringing data, actors & action in one place. It is a 6-8-member team including participation from government, social sector and MSME associations.
- Convene & Align Local Ecosystem: Of government offices (employment exchange, DC office, skills office and MSME associations, including their state level counterparts); not-for-profits (local NGOs that are connected to youth, women, businesses or local NGOs that are skillers); local startups and local industry players.
- Align focus: Discuss specific job roles & specific geographies within the district that should be targeted to get this off the ground quickly.
- Governance and R&R: Align roles & responsibilities of each actor and set up regular cadence & a governance mechanism with key stakeholders.

Step 2: Light Up Blue Dots

Start by making youth and jobs visible:

- **Bulk onboard youth, women and employers:** Upload data in batches from ITIs, colleges, MSME associations, NGOs and skilling centers.
- **Keep data simple:** For youth & women include name, contact, trade or skills, location, and willingness for local jobs. For employers, include role, number of openings, specific location, and salary.
- **Consent and visibility:** Send each youth, women and employer a confirmation nudge: "Your profile or job listing is ready for local visibility. Reply YES to go live."
- **Map activation:** Only those who consent become visible on the district map, ensuring authentic and actionable discovery.
- Within 2-4 weeks, a district can light up thousands of youth, women and hundreds of employers, all discoverable and searchable.

Step 3: Set Up the Jobs Facilitation Centre (JFC)

A JFC is an Institutional Structure that solves digital darkness by generation of blue dots of jobs & job seekers → then enables local actors to leverage these Blue Dots, so local employment grows, and actors benefit from it.

- Bring relevant departments together that can create Job Seeker Blue Dots: ITI Dept, Higher Ed Dept (BA/BCom), Polytechnic Dept, NGOs, Employment Exchanges
- Bring relevant departments together that can create Job Blue Dots: Bring employer-side depts together: Job side Depts: DIC (Industry), MSME Associations, Employment Exchange
- To Create Blue Dots, Unlock Govt & Institutional Databases: Alumni records, Job fair data, Udyam, Local schemes etc.
- To Leverage on Blue Dots, Invite and enable local ecosystem actors: Coaching centers, staffing firms, Hiring Agencies, Third Party Aggregators, MSME associations, YouTubers, Assessment Firms, Interview prep firms, Counseling firms. This empowerment gives local players (both NGOs and businesses) the "discovery infrastructure" so they can stop spending time on mobilizing people / businesses and instead focus on outcomes.
- Run monthly reviews and track outcomes: With all departments, led by DC/Local Lead

Step 4: Build a Daily, Weekly Rhythm

Predictability is key. Employment discovery should pulse like a heartbeat.

Frequency	Action
Daily	Create more Blue Dots of youth, women and employer data.
Weekly	Follow ups and nudges to update status to youth, women & employers ("Still looking for work?", "New jobs posted", "Still looking to hire?", "Shortlist applications") Engaging with local ecosystem to expand reach & bring in diverse services.
Monthly	Review meeting at JFC with DC, colleges, MSMEs & not-for-profits
Quarterly	District Employment Bulletin sharing data and progress
One-off job fairs	Continuous daily shortlists and interviews

When discovery becomes routine, hiring becomes reliable.

Step 5: Involve Local Innovators for Ancillary services

Once the rhythm is in place, local not-for-profits, startups and entrepreneurs can:

- Expand the pool of job seekers & job providers
- Create tools for bulk uploads, vernacular resumes, or map visualisation
- Serve as Attestors or Cataloguers for verification
- Add ancillary services like credit, transport, housing or training

When local innovators plug in, employment discovery becomes sustainable and self-improving.

If you would like to conduct a local placement drive then you can make the process more efficient through **DigiPass**.

In the context of organizing a placement drive: once an employer shortlists a youth/women, the JFC can facilitate further by issuing a DigiPass, a verified digital token that signals “shortlisted and authentic.”

- Youth/Women use the same DigiPass for multiple verified interviews.
- Employers save time and avoid screening uncertainty.

This builds credibility and predictability on both sides.

4. What You Should Leverage

- Existing Data from ITIs, colleges, NGOs, MSME clusters, and training centers
- Local Administration including DC office, Employment Exchange, DIC
- Local Ecosystem Partners such as foundations, skilling orgs, startups

5. Communication: Who, What and How

Successful pilots need clear and timely communication with key actors. This table shows who to engage, when, and what to communicate—from early setup to ongoing activation and innovation.

When to Engage	Who to Engage	What to Communicate / How to Engage
Day 1–7	District Administration (DC, Employment Exchange, Skills Office, MSME Associations)	Introduce the Blue Dot approach and its local relevance. Secure leadership buy-in, form a small PMU, set up the JFC and set review cadence.
	Ecosystem Partners	Share the vision and pilot goals. Explore how they can contribute—from mobilizing youth and employers to co-anchoring the JFC or bringing digital tools and capacity.
Week 2-3	ITIs, Colleges, Skilling Centers, Local NGOs connected to youth & women	Issue a circular through the District Officers authorizing participation. Follow up with simple communication to placement officers, NGOs on next steps for data sharing and youth/women activation. Explain how visibility on the district map benefits women, youth and alumni.
Week 3-4	MSME Associations/ Local Employers, Local NGOs connected to MSMEs	Engage via DIC or Employment Exchange. Communicate how local hiring becomes faster and more predictable when employers list verified openings.
Month 2 onward	Startups/Local Innovators	Invite participation once the rhythm stabilises. Encourage them to test tools, build local integrations, or design new verification or engagement features.
Ongoing	All Actors (coordinated by JFC)	Maintain rhythm: daily nudges for job seekers & job providers, weekly nudges to inspire coordinated action, data updates, and monthly progress reviews with stakeholders to ensure visibility and trust stay live.

6. What Is EkStep's Offer

EkStep can support in helping you pilot through the following:

- **Digital Public Goods (DPGs)**
- Ready-to-deploy digital components that can power the pilot, including tools for discovery (creating blue dots), verification, and seamless value exchange. There are 2 options:
 - **Option 1:** EkStep sets up a pilot instance of the DPGs on its sandbox to get the pilot going (however, any custom developments won't be possible during the pilot)
 - **Option 2:** The organization anchoring the pilot can take the DPGs to set up their own instance on a separate sandbox with a technology partner of their choice. EkStep can provide guidance, training & documentation to support. Refer to the tab – **Technical Playbook** if you are interested in this.
- **Brainstorming**
Collaborative sessions with the anchor partner to help shape the pilot's focus, approach, and success measures.
- **Templates & Learnings**
Share templates & learnings from Dharwad/Ghaziabad for aligning the local ecosystem, and for communication, nudges etc.
- **Ecosystem Linkages**
Connections to relevant partners who may wish to participate in pilots while keeping the local ecosystem in the lead.
- **Periodic Check-ins**
Periodic discussions to review progress, address blockers, and identify what can help sustain and scale the effort.

7. What Success Looks Like

- 1,000s of youth, women and employers visible on a live district digital map in 1 month
- 100s of applications & shortlists every week
- A daily/weekly rhythm that's growing continuously
- Local ecosystem is actively engaged
- Local startups get involved and trigger further innovation
- Hiring costs & time drop and roles fill in days
- The district becomes a digital employment exchange for local hiring

8. Why It Works

- Brings in local pride and efforts of the local ecosystem and sets a pathway for the local economy to thrive.
- Uses familiar interfaces eg. jobs on a map like restaurants on a map
- Combines bulk, consent, and nudges for scale and trust
- Builds agency for both youth and employers
- Prioritises visibility and verification over complexity
- Converts digital darkness into a living, verifiable digital employment ecosystem
- Surfaces avenues for innovation

9. Effort and Timeline estimates

We can divide the activation into 3 stages

Setup (1-2 months)

- Align key stakeholders and anchors (DC, Departments)
- Setup JFC Team
- Configure and setup DPGs (Tech)
- 'Identify your supply-demand matched use case (e.g. ITI freshers <> MSME jobs)
- Hire/align people part of JFC
- Locate and onboard your key supply/demand aggregators

Activate (1-2 months)

- Onboard JFC Team & Assign Goals
- Unlock databases from various sources
- Start Creation blue dots for job seeker/providers
- Kickstart Review Rhythm
- Run blue-dotathons and campaigns to get micro-wins
- Blue dot other service providers relevant to the use case

Drive Outcomes (1-2 months)

- Get local service providers to leverage blue dots (Staffing firms, NGOs, Skilling Partners)
- Track the funnel for placement outcomes & skilling outcomes
- Develop reporting and governance cadence - Monthly DC Reviews, District Dashboards
- Fix bottlenecks. Build learnings on what works/doesn't work for future iterations

Appendix

Key Resources

- **ONEST Concept Paper**

Explains the foundational vision and building blocks of ONEST, designed to enable timely and trusted discovery of employment.

- Read the [ONEST Concept Paper](#)

- **The Blue Dot Experiment in Dharwad (Mint Article)**

A feature article detailing how the Dharwad pilot demonstrated the power of visibility and trust in transforming local employment.

- Read the [Mint Article](#)

- **ONEST Overview Deck**

An outline of an ecosystem approach to unlocking India's demographic dividend through ONEST's digital public infrastructure in the making and the Blue Dot approach.

- **View the** [ONEST Deck](#)

- **ONEST Packages**

A comprehensive guide to ONEST-relevant Digital Public Goods (DPGs) from EkStep Foundation—featuring ready-to-deploy components for discovery (creating Blue Dots), verification, and value exchange, with clear setup options, implementation steps, and guidance for partners to go live through EkStep's sandbox or their own instance.

- Read: [ONEST Job Stack](#)

- **Blue Dot Job Map**

Experience how youth are finding local, verified jobs on a live digital map—the Blue Dot approach in action.

- Visit the [Reference Web App](#)

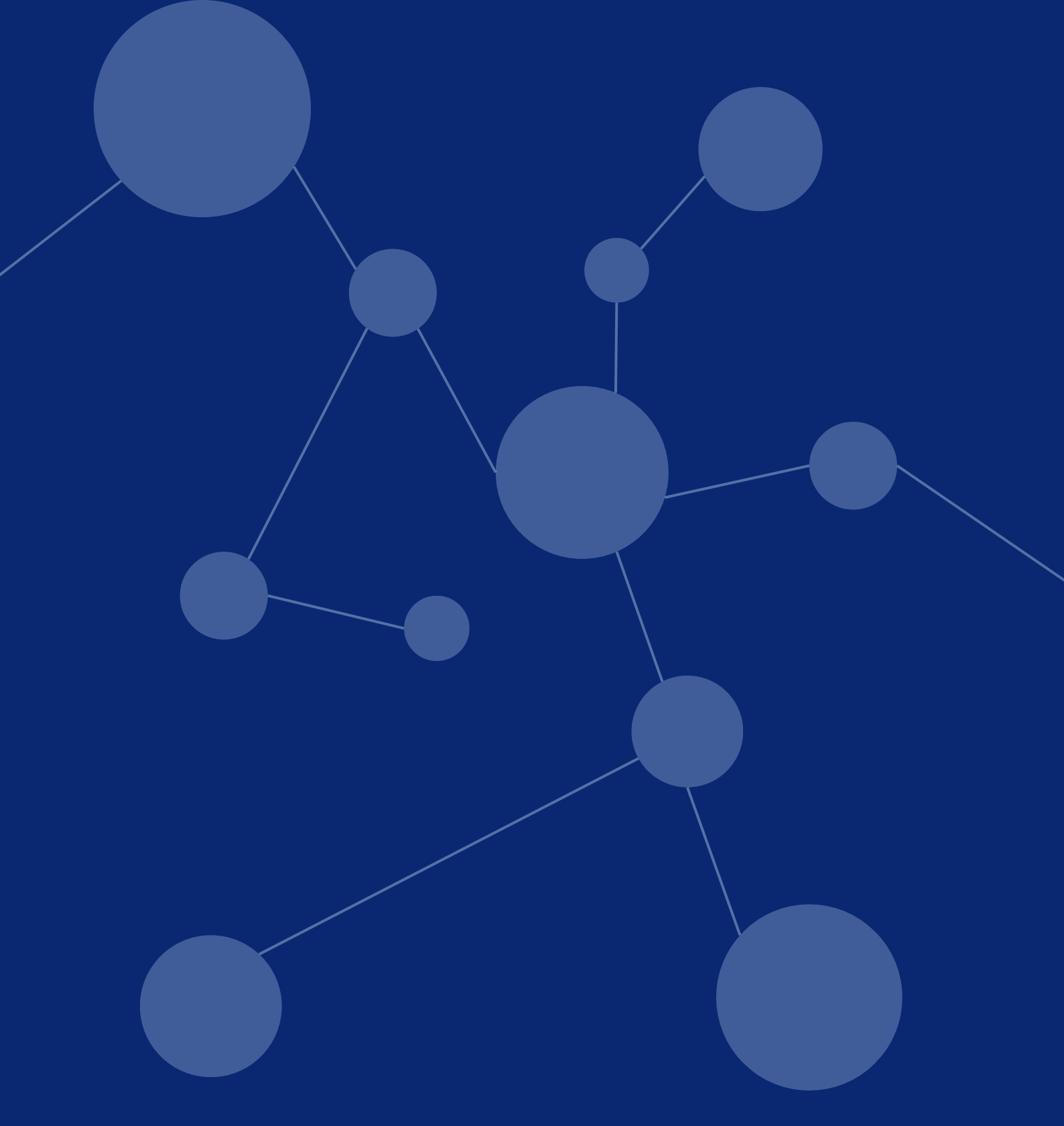
- **Voice Bots for Youth and Employers**

AI-driven tools that help youth create profiles and employers post openings effortlessly—all through simple voice interactions.

- Watch Demo: [Create a Biodata in Under Two Minutes \(for youth\)](#)
- Watch Demo: [List a Local Job Using Voice \(for MSMEs\)](#)

Acronyms

DC	: District Commissioner
DIC	: District Industries Centre
DPG	: Digital Public Good
ITI	: Industrial Training Institute
JFC	: Jobs Facilitation Centre
MSME	: Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises
NGO	: Non-Governmental Organisation
PMU	: Project Management Unit
R & R	: Roles and Responsibilities
UPI	: Unified Payments Interface



**SCAN HERE TO ACCESS THE DISTRICT
LIVELIHOODS PLAYBOOK**

